

Medical Bill Financial Assistance

Facing a medical bill you can't pay? Hospitals are often legally required to forgive or reduce bills, and charities help cover treatment costs. Below are trusted national starting points. Tick the box once you've contacted each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Don't ignore a medical bill or put it on a credit card before checking these options. Nonprofit hospitals must offer financial assistance ("charity care"), and asking can wipe out or shrink your bill — even after it's sent.

1 Ask the Hospital for Charity Care

Nonprofit hospitals are required by law to have a financial assistance policy that can reduce or erase your bill.

☐ Dollar For — Hospital Bill Help

A free nonprofit that checks if you qualify for hospital charity care and helps you apply.

→ dollarfor.org

☐ Ask for the "Financial Assistance Policy"

Call the hospital billing department and request their Financial Assistance Policy application. They must provide it; collections pause while it's pending.

→ **Call your hospital's billing department**

2 Get Help With Treatment Costs

Charities provide grants for copays, treatment, and related costs for many conditions.

☐ PAN Foundation

Grants to help with copays and out-of-pocket costs for dozens of conditions.

→ www.panfoundation.org

☐ Patient Advocate Foundation

Free case managers plus a co-pay relief fund to help with medical costs.

→ www.patientadvocate.org

☐ HealthWell Foundation

Grants for copays, premiums, and out-of-pocket costs for many illnesses.

→ www.healthwellfoundation.org

3 Check Your Bill for Errors

Medical bills are often wrong. Your legal rights can lower what you owe.

☐ No Surprises Act — Fight Surprise Bills

Protects you from many surprise out-of-network charges. If a bill exceeds your Good Faith Estimate by \$400+, you can dispute it.

→ www.cms.gov/medical-bill-rights

☐ Request an Itemized Bill

Always ask for a line-by-line itemized bill and check for errors or duplicate charges before paying.

→ **Ask your provider for an itemized bill**

4 Set Up Affordable Payments

If you do owe, you have options besides paying it all at once.

☐ Ask for a Payment Plan or Discount

Many providers offer interest-free payment plans or a discount if you ask — especially for paying cash.

→ Ask your provider's billing office

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never put a big medical bill on a high-interest credit card or a medical credit card before applying for charity care — once it's on a card, the hospital's assistance no longer applies. And debt collectors must pause while your charity-care application is pending.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Apply for charity care even if the bill already arrived or feels old — it can still be forgiven. Always ask for an itemized bill first; billing errors are common and can lower what you owe before assistance is even calculated.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help with a specific bill?

This guide covers national starting points. For help applying to your hospital's program or finding condition-specific aid, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we'll walk through it with you.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
